Enter the rabbit hole

Immersion has always been the goal for all forms of media since their emergence, with each new technological advancement bringing them closer to real life. Movies went from black and white to colour, from silent to sound, then from 2 Dimensional presentations to 3 Dimensional. Sound started off as a single source, went stereo and now we have surround sound with all home-theatre setups. Even graphics within games followed a similar trajectory towards hyper-realism. As a next step it is only natural that we have taken all of it further and tried to emulate reality itself.

Even though Virtual Reality (VR) has been around for the last three decades, it is only recently that we have had sufficiently developed technology at our disposal to experience it at the mass level at an acceptably high quality. You have to be on FreeBasics if you are on the internet and yet haven't encountered the Oculus Rift, a massively popular VR headset that released commercially to the general public recently. This sudden popularity promises to change the way we experience a lot of things – games, websites, movies, specialised training, tourism and more. Facebook's acquisition of Oculus and Valve's collaboration with HTC have served to bring VR into mainstream and Google's Cardboard initiative has brought it to the masses.

We begin this Fastrack by exploring what VR is through its origin and basic principles in Chapter 1. From its earliest days in the first few decades of the century, VR has come a long way, both in terms of technology and also in the principles on which it works. And from where we stand now, the market is full of VR devices that employ a host of technologies to achieve greater and greater accuracy and immersive depth in VR, and we take you through some of the most significant players and their products in Chapter 2.